SERVICE SUSPENDED

Episode 2 — The Dungeon Crawler

Full Narrative Script

ACT 1 — THE TRAIN

Opening — The Bedroom

[Morning. The alarm goes off at 6:47. Player has no control.]

6:47.

Same as yesterday.

Same as the day before that.

[The hand reaches out and silences it before the eyes open. Muscle memory. The ceiling comes into focus.]

There's a crack up there. Right corner. Been there since you moved in.

You keep meaning to fix it.

[Pause.]

You never do.

[Player gains control. Standard morning routine — no choices that matter yet. Phone buzzes on the nightstand.]

Work email. Same subject line it always is.

You don't read it.

[Player heads to the station.]

Platform 7B — First Visit

[The platform. Digital board reads 7:15 - MILLBANK - ON TIME. Same crowd as always.]

Woman in a red coat near the yellow line. Newspaper folded to the crossword. She hasn't looked up once.

Businessman. Watch check. Three seconds. Watch check again.

Teenager with headphones. Head bobbing to something you can't hear.

Same as yesterday. Same as the day before that.

[The train pulls in. Player boards.]

On the Train — The Anomaly

[Interior. Player sits. Twenty-three minutes to Millbank. The tunnel approaches.]

The lights flicker in the tunnel. Standard. Always happens here.

[First flicker. The passenger sitting across — something is wrong with their face.]

You look up.

[Second flicker.]

Their face is wrong.

Not wrong like sick. Wrong like — it isn't finished. Like something is wearing it loosely.

[Lights snap back on. The passenger is normal. Reading their phone. Completely ordinary.]

You stare at them for a long moment.

They don't notice.

Or they're pretending not to.

[Pause. Something shifts. Somewhere in the carriage a sound — like something being written down.]

You look around.

Nothing.

Just the train.

Clack-clack. Clack-clack.

The Hole Punch

[Player arrives at Millbank. Goes through the day. Returns to the platform for the evening commute. Platform 7B again.]

Something is on the ground near the yellow line.

You almost walk past it.

[Player interacts. It's a hole punch. Old. Brass and black. Heavier than it should be.]

Nobody around you reacts. Nobody even looks at it.

Like it isn't there for them.

[A ticket materialises next to it. Same yellowed paper. Handwritten text.]

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SPECIAL TRANSFER
PLATFORM: UNLISTED
VALID: INDEFINITELY
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Your name isn't on it. No origin. No destination.

You pick up the punch.

[Choice appears.]

- Punch the ticket.
- Leave it.

> *If player leaves it: the ticket and punch are still there the next morning. And the morning after. Until they punch it. The loop cannot begin without consent. This is important.*

The Punch

[Player punches the ticket.]

The sound it makes isn't right.

Too loud. Too final. Like something sealing shut rather than opening.

[The ticket begins to smoke from the hole outward. Black. No heat. The ash rises instead of falling.]

The platform is gone.

The train is gone.

The light is gone.

[Silence. Then — a long, low sound. Like a train that never arrives.]

Then the floor.

ACT 2 — THE DUNGEON

Loop 1 — Arrival

[Player spawns. The environment is dark. Stone walls but with transit infrastructure embedded in them — overhead handles, yellow safety lines painted on uneven ground, flickering fluorescent strips bolted to cave ceilings. It shouldn't exist. It does.]

The air is stale. Sealed.

Like this place has been here a long time waiting for someone to arrive.

[Objective appears: Explore your surroundings.]

[Player gains control.]

There's no way back up.

You check anyway.

First Ticket Discovery

[Player explores. A ticket is visible further down the corridor. When player gets close:]

Another one.

[Player picks it up. Same yellowed paper. Same texture]

SPECIAL TRANSFER. Platform Unlisted. Valid Indefinitely.

You don't know what it opens. You don't know what punching it does.

[Pause.]

You punched the last one and ended up here.

You put it in your pocket.

First Encounter — The Woman

[Further into the first area. The player sees her before she sees them. Red coat. Worn now in a way it wasn't on the platform. She's sitting against the wall doing nothing. No newspaper. Just waiting.]

You recognize her.

The woman from the platform. Red coat. She was reading a newspaper.

She isn't reading anything now.

[She looks up. No surprise on her face. Just a kind of tired recognition.]

WOMAN
You punched it.

[Not a question.]

PLAYER
What is this place.

WOMAN
Below the platform. Below the station. Below whatever you think the normal world is.

[Pause.]

WOMAN
It doesn't have a name. I stopped trying to name it a while ago.

PLAYER
How long have you been down here.

[She thinks about it. Genuinely thinks, like the answer requires excavation.]

WOMAN
I don't know anymore. That's not me being vague. I genuinely cannot tell you.

[Pause.]

WOMAN

Time moves differently here. And the longer you stay the more of it you lose.

PLAYER

Lose how.

WOMAN

Every loop takes something. Small things first. What you had for dinner last Tuesday. The name of someone you went to school with. Then bigger things.

[She pauses. Something passes across her face.]

WOMAN

I can't remember what my life looked like anymore. I know I had one. I know there were things I genuinely looked forward to, but they are all gone now.

[Silence.]

PLAYER

What do I do.

WOMAN

You collect tickets. Each one you find is a piece of a way out. Punch enough of them in the right order and a door opens.

[Pause.]

PLAYER

And you. Why haven't you left.

[A long pause. She looks at her hands.]

WOMAN

I don't remember what I'd be going back to.

[She says it quietly. Not for sympathy. Just as a fact she has made peace with.]

WOMAN
Find the tickets. Don't stay in one place too long. And don't let him see you if you can help it.

PLAYER
Who.

[She doesn't answer that yet. Just nods deeper into the dungeon.]

WOMAN
Go.

The Loops — Mid Game

[Player progresses through levels. Collects tickets. Punches them to advance through doors and unlock new areas. Each punch deepens the loop. After enough punches:]

Something is different.

You can't place it at first.

[Pause.]

Then you can.

You can't remember the name of the street you grew up on.

[Later loop:]

Your mother's face. You can feel the shape of it. The warmth of it.

But when you try to see it clearly it slides away.

[Later still:]

You stand in a corridor for a moment trying to remember why you took this job.

The commute. The office. The reports.

What were you doing it for.

[Pause.]

You can't find the answer.

You keep moving.

Second Encounter — The Woman

[Mid-game. Player finds her again in a different area. She's standing this time. Watching the player approach.]

WOMAN
How many have you punched.

PLAYER
Enough. I think I'm close.

WOMAN
You're doing better than most.

[Pause. The player can ask questions here.]

PLAYER CHOICE

- "Who is he. The one you wouldn't name."
- "Did you ever try to escape."
- "What were you like. Before."

IF: "WHO IS HE."

WOMAN
The conductor.

[Pause.]

WOMAN

He runs this place. Manages it. Files people into permanent loops when they've been down here long enough.

PLAYER

Files them?

WOMAN

Assigns them a route. A permanent one. After that you don't try to leave anymore. You just — commute. Down here. The same path. Indefinitely.

[Pause.]

WOMAN

He hasn't filed me because I'm not worth the paperwork. Too degraded. Too far gone to be useful to the system.

[She says it without bitterness. That's the worst part.]

IF: "DID YOU EVER TRY TO ESCAPE."

WOMAN

Yes. Early on. I found what I thought was a way out.

[Pause.]

WOMAN

It wasn't. It just went deeper.

PLAYER

What stopped you from trying again?

[She considers this.]

WOMAN

At some point I stopped being able to remember why leaving mattered.

[Pause.]

WOMAN

That's how you know the loops are working. When staying starts to feel the same as going.

IF: "WHAT WERE YOU LIKE. BEFORE."

[A long silence. She genuinely tries.]

WOMAN

I read a lot. I remember that. I had a newspaper habit. Crosswords specifically.

[Pause.]

WOMAN

I don't remember if I was happy. I remember the crosswords. That's what's left.

[Pause. Something in her face closes over.]

WOMAN

Don't lose too much before you get out. The things you can't remember — you don't miss them until you're back and they're just gone.

[Beat.]

WOMAN

At least I think that's how it works. I've never made it back to check.

The Intercom — Mid to Late Game

[After enough loops the intercom begins. Sporadic at first. Then more frequent.]

The intercom crackles.

INTERCOM

Passenger deviation noted.

[Static. Silence. Later:]

INTERCOM

Continued irregular movement. Route reassignment pending.

[Later still. The voice is different now. Less automated. More present.]

INTERCOM

You've gone further than most.

[Pause.]

INTERCOM

That won't change where this ends.

Third Encounter — The Woman

[Near the end of the dungeon. She finds the player this time. Her coat is more worn. Something is different in her posture — not quite hope, but something adjacent to it. She's been watching the player progress.]

WOMAN

You're actually going to make it.

[She sounds like she hasn't said that about anyone in a long time.]

PLAYER

Come with me.

[Pause. She looks away.]

WOMAN

I don't know if there's anything left to go back to. Even if I got out.

PLAYER

You could find out.

[A long silence. Something shifts in her. Small. Almost imperceptible.]

WOMAN
Find the last door. I'll think about it.

[Pause.]

WOMAN
He's going to come himself for you. Once you get close enough he won't send the intercom anymore.

PLAYER
What do I do when he does.

WOMAN
Don't resist. Not yet. Let him think he has you.

[Pause.]

WOMAN
And whatever you do — hold onto something specific. A memory. Something small and exact. The more specific the better.

PLAYER
Why.

WOMAN
Because he can't file someone who's still specific. The system needs you to be generic. A passenger. Not a person.

[She holds eye contact for a moment longer than she needs to.]

WOMAN
Go.

ACT 3 — THE CONDUCTOR

The Final Door

[Player reaches the last area. A wide chamber. Floor tiled like Platform 7B. Yellow safety line across the entire space. In the centre — a final ticket. No enemies. No music. Just the sound of something very far away that might be a train.]

This is it.

[Pause.]

Has to be.

[Player moves toward it. The fluorescent lights above snap to full brightness. The stone walls around the chamber begin to change — train panels overlaying the rock. Overhead handles. The smell of platform concrete and electrical heat.]

The dungeon isn't hiding anymore.

It looks like the station now.

It always did.

The Conductor Arrives

[Heavy footsteps. Slow. Not rushing. He emerges from the far end of the chamber. His uniform is dark — too dark, like the colour itself is wrong. His face is pale and carries no expression. He doesn't blink at the right intervals. He walks like someone who has never needed to hurry because nothing has ever successfully run from him.]

He's not distorted.

That's the worst thing about him.

He just looks — correct. Like the room makes more sense with him in it.

[He stops. Looks at the player. Then at the ticket on the ground between them.]

CONDUCTOR

There you are.

[His voice is flat. Not robotic. Just completely emptied of anything that isn't function. He looks at the player the way someone looks at a document they've been waiting a long time to read.]

[Player movement begins to slow. The chamber feels heavier.]

CONDUCTOR
You've been irregular since the platform.

[Pause. He takes one step closer.]

CONDUCTOR
Too much movement. Too many routes. Passengers don't navigate. They ride.

[Pause.]

CONDUCTOR
But you — you saw something on the train. Most of them never see anything.

[He tilts his head slightly. Studying.]

CONDUCTOR
That's why I've been watching you.

[Pause. The weight of that lands. Through the crack. All this time.]

PLAYER
You put the hole punch there. On the platform.

[He doesn't deny it.]

CONDUCTOR
I needed to see what you'd do with it.

[Pause.]

CONDUCTOR
You passed that part.

[He reaches the ticket on the ground. Picks it up without looking at it. Eyes on the player the entire time.]

PLAYER
What do you want from me.

[A pause. Something almost registers on his face. Like a question he has been waiting to answer for a very long time.]

CONDUCTOR
This position requires someone who can see the anomalies. Who notices when the system is showing through.

[Pause.]

CONDUCTOR
I've been here long enough.

[He says it without complaint. Without emotion. Just as a fact he has catalogued and accepted.]

PLAYER
You want a replacement.

[He looks at the player for a long moment.]

CONDUCTOR
I want someone who is ready for it.

[Pause.]

CONDUCTOR
You're not. Not yet.

[He looks at the ticket for the first time. Then back at the player.]

CONDUCTOR

But you collected quite a few.

[Pause.]

CONDUCTOR
It won't matter. Not today.

[He produces a box. Small. Metal. Slides it open.]

He places the ticket inside.

Then, one by one, your inventory opens automatically.

Every ticket you collected.

They lift from your pockets.

Float to the box.

[He closes the lid. A sound like something locking that has never been unlocked.]

The box begins to glow. Faint. Orange.

Then the tickets inside begin to burn.

You can hear them.

[Pause. The player tries to move. Can't.]

CONDUCTOR
Irregular passengers get reassigned.

[He steps aside. Behind him — a train carriage. It wasn't there before. The doors are open. Inside: two seats, fluorescent lighting, the familiar blue-grey fabric. A perfect ordinary commuter carriage at the bottom of the world.]

CONDUCTOR

Your new route is ready.

[Pause. The player is being moved toward it. Slowly. Against their will. He walks alongside. Not touching. Not needing to.]

You can't stop moving toward it.

You look around for her.

The red coat.

She isn't here.

[The carriage doors.]

The last thing you see before the doors close is the chamber. The yellow line on the floor. The burned-out box on the ground.

Then the doors shut.

Then the light changes.

Then nothing.

The New Carriage

[Interior. The player is seated. Doors sealed. Fluorescent lights. No windows. Silence except for the sound of rails — but no movement. The sound without the motion.]

This isn't the same carriage.

[Pause.]

There's no one else here.

[Player stands. Tries the compartment doors. Locked. Tries the emergency handle. Doesn't move. Tries the windows. Sealed.]

[The intercom clicks on. His voice. Clear and close, like he's in the next room.]

CONDUCTOR
Rest now.

[Pause.]

CONDUCTOR
Your new route begins shortly.

[Silence.]

The lights dim.

The sound of the rails beneath you slows.

Then stops.

[Complete darkness. Complete silence.]

[Fade to black.]

— TO BE CONTINUED —

SERVICE SUSPENDED — END OF EPISODE 2

Episode 3: The Escape Room | Episode 4: Exit